TABLE TALKS · FREE LESSON PACK · BELOVED, REALLY

The Father who *runs.*

A GUIDE FOR ONE HONEST CONVERSATION

robe, ring, sandals, party



1 · LESSON RECAP
2 · BACK STORY
3 · TALK IT THROUGH
4 · MEMORY CARDS
5 · COLORING PAGE

"But while he was still a long way off, his father saw him and was filled with compassion for him; he ran to his son."

LUKE 15:20 · NIV

Chaotic Sunshine

The Father who *runs.*

Everything for one honest conversation: the lesson, the back story, the questions, memory cards and a coloring page.

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LESSON RECAP

You rehearsed the speech. He ran before you could finish it.

The younger son practiced his apology the whole way home: I'm not worthy, make me a hired servant (Luke 15:18-19). He never got to the servant part. His father saw him a long way off, ran, hugged him and called for the best robe. God watches the road for you, and when He sees you, He runs.

THE WORD LUKE USED

splanchnizomai

GREEK · SPLANGKH-NID-ZOH-MY

Filled with compassion. It comes from the word for the gut: love that hits you in the stomach before anyone says a word.

	The father we expect	The Father Jesus described
WAITS FOR	A full apology	You, a long way off
MOVES	Arms crossed at the door	Runs down the road
GIVES	Probation	Robe, ring, sandals, a party

> ***"So he got up and went to his father. But while he was still a long way off, his father saw him and was filled with compassion for him; he ran to his son, threw his arms around him and kissed him."***
>
> LUKE 15:20 · NIV

TAKE THIS HOME

You don't have to finish the speech.

THE SPEECH HE REHEARSED · LUKE 15:18-19 · NIV

"Father, I have sinned against heaven and against you. I am no longer worthy to be called your son; ~~make me like one of your hired servants.~~"

he never got to that last line (15:21-22).

robe. ring. sandals. party.

THE BACK STORY

Meanwhile, at a table full of sinners...

STORYTELLER ID CARD

Told by: Jesus
Written down by: Luke, a doctor (Colossians 4:14) who investigated carefully (Luke 1:1-4)
Audience: tax collectors, sinners and grumbling religious leaders (15:1-2)
Format: three lost-and-found stories in a row

the original lost and found.

What was going on

Tax collectors and sinners were crowding in to hear Jesus. The Pharisees and teachers of the law muttered, "This man welcomes sinners and eats with them" (Luke 15:1-2). So Jesus told three stories.

In the third, a younger son asks for his share of the estate early (15:12), spends it all, and ends up feeding pigs in a famine (15:13-16). For a Jewish listener, that's rock bottom: the law called pigs unclean (Leviticus 11:7).

Read the chapter like a playlist

15:1–2
The grumbling. "This man welcomes sinners."

15:3–10
Lost sheep, lost coin. Heaven throws a party.

15:11–24
The son who left, and the father who ran.

15:25–32
The son who stayed. Next week's story.

Why it matters

Many scholars note that in that culture a dignified older man did not run; he would have had to hike up his robe. This father runs anyway.

Then he gives a robe, a ring, sandals and a feast before any proof of changed behavior (15:22-24). Jesus told this to people who kept score, so they could see a Father who doesn't.

SO WHAT?

You don't have to finish the speech. He's already running.

no probation period.

What each gift said

As many commentators read the customs behind Luke 15:22-23.

THE BEST ROBE
Honor. Everyone can see he's welcome.

A RING
Family standing, not a probation badge.

SANDALS
A son, not a servant.

THE PARTY
"Lost and is found." Joy, out loud (15:24).

TALK IT THROUGH · ABOUT 45 MINUTES

Pull up a chair.

BRING
A snack, a pen and your honest self.

WHO
3 to 8 friends. "Pass" is always allowed.

TABLE RULE
What's shared here stays here.

SPARK · 5 MIN

What's the best homecoming you've ever had? Airport hug, surprise visit, a dog who lost its mind when you walked in?

host goes first.

READ IT OUT LOUD · 5 MIN

Read **Luke 15:11-24** together. Listen for the moment the son's speech gets interrupted.

QUESTIONS · 25 MIN · START LIGHT, GO DEEPER

1. What speech do you tend to rehearse before coming to God?
2. Why do you think Jesus told this story to the people who were grumbling (Luke 15:1-2)?
3. The father ran, which many scholars say looked undignified. What does it tell you that God would look a little ridiculous to reach you?
4. Which gift is hardest for you to accept: the robe, the ring, the sandals or the party? Why?

! **Deep End:** Where are you still standing "a long way off," and what would it look like to let Him reach you this week?

NO PREAMBLE
Come to God today with no speech. Just say, "I'm here."

WRITE IT
Cut out a memory card (page 4) and keep it in your car, where the speeches happen.

RUN FIRST
Text someone you've drifted from before they reach out.

CLOSE IN PRAYER

Father, we came with our speeches ready. Thank You for running toward us before we could finish. We set them down and receive Your welcome, the robe, the ring and the party. Amen.

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SCAN TO SIGN UP

4 • Memory verse cards

CUT ON THE DASHED LINES

MEMORY VERSE

"So he got up and went to his father. But while he was still a long way off, his father saw him and was filled with compassion for him; he ran to his son, threw his arms around him and kissed him."

LUKE 15:20 · NIV

MIRROR CARD

...he *ran* to his son...

LUKE 15:20 · NIV

tape me where you get ready.

POCKET REMINDER

Skip the speech.

This week: come to God with no preamble. Just say, "I'm here."

robe. ring. sandals. party.

COLOR ME

ooohe ran to his son

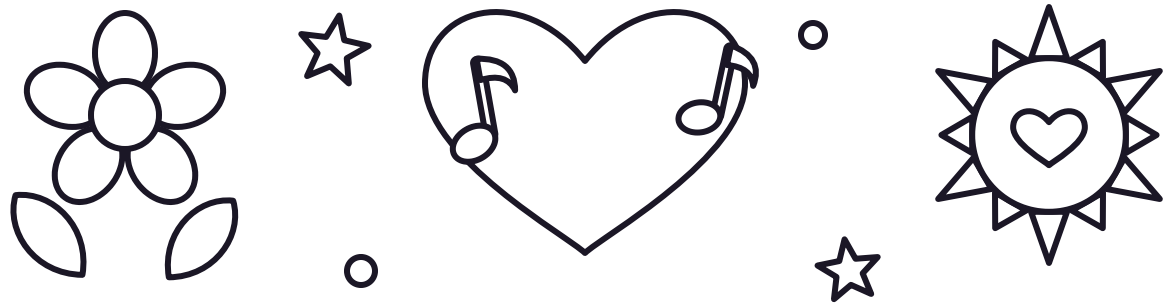
LUKE 15:20 · NIV



...he ran to his son

...threw his arms around him and kissed him.

LUKE 15:20 · NIV



Margin Notes

The speech I'm done rehearsing:

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